Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K Q 9 8 7 5 2 ♥ A 2 ♦ A 2 ♣ 5 2	
♠ — ♥ 10 9 6 3 ♦ K Q J 9 4 ♣ Q 10 9 7		♠ 10 3 ♥ K Q J 8 4 ♦ 10 8 7 5 ♣ J 8
	♠ A J 6 4 ♥ 7 5 ♦ 6 3 ♣ A K 6 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	1♠	Pass	2♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥K

North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥5 and West the ♥3.

You win the ♥A and draw trumps with the ♠K and ♠Q.

East plays low.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 2

One of the two red losers must be discarded on dummy's ♣ suit. So you pull trumps, taking two rounds, with ♠K and ♠Q. Then play two top ♣s and ruff a ♣. When East shows out on the third ♣, enter dummy with a trump and ruff another ♣. Dummy's final ♣ is now established, so enter dummy with another trump and discard one of the red losers on the fifth ♣.

As long as the ♣s were no worse than 4-2 you can establish the suit.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A 8 ♥ Q 10 8 2 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ J 10 9 7	
♠ 10 9 7 2 ♥ A J 6 ♦ 7 5 ♣ Q 6 4 3	N W E S	♠ Q J 5 ♥ K 5 4 3 ♦ A 4 3 ♣ A K 5
	♠ K 6 4 3 ♥ 9 7 ♦ K 10 8 6 2 ♣ 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	
All Pass			

1NT by East
Lead: ♦6

East is to play 1NT. South leads the ♦6, taken by North with the ♦J. North next plays the ♦Q on which South plays the ♦2. North plays the ♦9 which you finally win.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 6

You only need one more winner and you have several possibilities. The ♥ finesse might work, or the ♣s might split 3-3. But you need to consider the defenders winners also. They have already scored 2 ♦ tricks and will get 2 more as soon as they gain the lead. (The spot cards told you that South has a 5-card ♦ suit.) Plus they have the 2 top ♠s which they can take whenever they like. So if your play sets up just one more trick for them you will go down.

No, you must establish ♠s, the suit where they have 2 winners anyway. So you play a ♠ which South wins. He takes his 2 ♦s but you are now home free. When you gain the lead again you will get your ♠ winner established and only lose 2 ♠s and 4 ♦s.

If you finessed the ♥ you would have gone down with the defenders winning 4 ♦s, 1 ♥ and 2 ♠s.

If you had played 3 rounds of ♣s you would have gone down with the defenders winning 4 ♦s, 1 ♣ and 2 ♠s.

Only by establishing ♠s can you make the contract.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q 10 2 ♥ 8 6 ♦ 9 5 2 ♣ A 10 9 8 3	
♠ 9 8 6 5 3 ♥ Q 9 3 2 ♦ K 4 ♣ 6 2	N W E S	♠ A 4 ♥ J 10 4 ♦ Q J 10 6 ♣ J 7 5 4
	♠ K J 7 ♥ A K 7 5 ♦ A 8 7 3 ♣ K Q	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠9

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠9, taken by East with the ♠A. East next plays the ♠4.

You win with the ♠K and West plays low.

Everyone follows low.

West plays low.

East follows with the ♣5.

East wins with the ♣J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 8

You only need one more winner and if ♦s split 3-3 you can easily establish a trick in that suit. But what if ♦s split 4-2? If the ♣J falls you can get an extra ♣ trick. In fact, no matter how the ♣s are arranged you can establish your extra trick there.

First make sure that you win the second trick with the ♠K, keeping dummy's ♠Q for a later entry. Then play ♣K, and ♣Q overtaking with dummy's ♣A. Then play the ♣10, losing to the ♣J but establishing the ♣9 while you still have the ♠Q as an entry.

As you see, you couldn't set up a ♦ trick so the ♣ overtake was necessary to make the contract.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q 10 4 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ 9 3 2 ♣ K Q J 10	
♠ 7 6 3 ♥ A K 5 2 ♦ A 8 6 ♣ A 7 5		♠ A 8 5 2 ♥ Q 7 ♦ K 7 4 ♣ 8 6 4 3
	♠ K J 9 ♥ J 10 8 4 ♦ Q J 10 5 ♣ 9 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♥	Pass	2NT	
All Pass			

2NT by West
Lead: ♣K

West is to play 2NT. North leads the ♣K, dummy plays the ♣3 and South the ♣2.

North plays low.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=3 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 7

You need to find another winner and the chances are not good. If either black suit splits 3-3 you can establish dummy's fourth card in that suit. But with North's opening lead of the ♣K it is unlikely that ♣s will split. So your only slim hope is that the ♠s split 3-3 and dummy's fourth ♠ will be a winner.

Win the first trick and play a ♠ to the ♠A. Then play another ♠. The defense will win and probably take some ♣ tricks . When they have finished and play a red card, you win it and play a third round of ♠s. If both defenders follow to all three ♠s then dummy's ♠8 is now a winner.

This time you were lucky and the ♠s split evenly. Next time they probably won't and you'll go down.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

♠ Q
♥ Q 10 9 7 6
♦ A J 3
♣ A 7 4 2

♠ A K 9 7
♥ 4 2
♦ K 10 8 4
♣ 9 6 5

♠ J 10 4
♥ 8 3
♦ Q 9 7 2
♣ K Q J 10

♠ 8 6 5 3 2
♥ A K J 5
♦ 6 5
♣ 8 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♣K

North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♣K, dummy plays the ♣3 and West the ♣5.

West wins the ♠K.

West plays a trump, you follow low and East too.

Dummy leads a ♠ and West plays low.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 6

Obviously you don't really have 6 losers since some of those ♦s and ♣s can be ruffed in dummy. But if you are playing against competent defenders you will only be able to ruff two of them because every time they get the lead they will play a trump. So you must figure on ruffing 2 losers and establishing dummy's fifth ♠ for a discard of the other one.

Win the ♣A and immediately play your ♠Q. The defense will win this trick and probably play a trump. Be sure to win this in dummy and then ruff a ♠ with a high ♥. Now exit with a ♣. They will win and probably play another trump. Win this one in dummy also, breathing a sigh of relief when ♥s split 2-2. Ruff another ♠ with your second-last trump, then play ♦A and concede a ♦.

Whichever minor suit the defense plays next you ruff in dummy, then ruff the fourth ♠, establishing dummy's ♠8 while you still have a trump left in dummy. Dummy is now high.

It took a 2-2 trump split and a 4-3 ♠ split. But that was your best shot.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ Q 10 4 ♥ Q 10 9 6 ♦ 9 3 2 ♣ 7 6 3	
♠ 8 7 5 ♥ K 8 7 5 3 ♦ A K 5 ♣ 10 2	N W E S	♠ A K 2 ♥ A 4 ♦ 8 4 ♣ A K Q J 9 5
	♠ J 9 6 3 ♥ J 2 ♦ Q J 10 7 6 ♣ 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2♣	Pass
2♥	Pass	3♣	Pass
3NT	Pass	4NT[1]	Pass
5♦[2]	Pass	5NT[3]	Pass
6♥[4]	Pass	7♣	
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace
3. asks for kings
4. 2 kings

7♣ by East
Lead: ♦Q

East is to play 7♣. South leads the ♦Q.

North plays the ♦2 and you the ♦4.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=0 ♣=0 Total = 1

It should be very clear that the only way to get rid of that ♠ loser is to discard it on dummy's ♥ suit. So after taking the first trick with dummy's ♦A you could pull trumps, then play ♥A, ♥K and ruff a ♥. **IF** the ♥s split 3-3 you could then enter dummy with the ♦K and discard your loser.

The problem is that the ♥s are much more likely to split 4-2, in which case you will need to ruff twice to establish a winner. That means you will need an extra entry to dummy.

That extra entry can only be the ♣10 so you must delay pulling trumps until after you ruff the first ♥. Win the ♦A and immediately play ♥A, ♥K and ruff a ♥ with a high ♣. South discards on this ♥ play. Enter dummy with a trump and ruff another ♥ high. The suit is now established, so you pull trumps, enter dummy one last time with the ♦K and discard that losing ♠ on the good ♥8.

It may have seemed too risky to play ♥s before pulling trumps. In fact, there was no risk at all. If the ♥s were splitting 5-1 then you had absolutely no chance of making the contract.

And if they had split 3-3 this Plan would still have worked.